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"I lost 25 kg in six months in 2020. I didn't go to a dietician or follow any diet–I just cut out added sugar, rice, carbonated drinks and controlled my portion sizes. I have realised it's all about balance, and my approach to eating has changed"

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the key player being insulin, which transfers glucose from food to your cells for energy or storage. It is produced every time you consume food. When one eats less, eats foods that have no glucose, or simply doesn't eat, there is automatically less insulin in the body. This decrease tells your brain that the body's energy needs have to be met from previously stored fat. Your fat cells then release fatty acid molecules that are broken down into energy. Dieting, thus, is not just about your body beginning to burn stored fat, but also about how, over time, it starts transferring energy from food to the organs directly, instead of storing it first. Based on these concepts, most health management services focus on seven programmes—Keto, intermittent fasting, no-added-sugar diet, plant-based diet, high protein-high fibre diet, Ayurvedic dosha diet, and a low carb-low fat diet (see *The Science Behind Popular Diets*).

Diets rich in fibre also trigger two other hormones that help reduce calorie intake: Leptin and Glucagon-like peptide-1. These tell the appetite-regulating part of your brain that you are full. It is why even the strictest of low-carb diets, such as the Dukan Diet, suggest including some amount of healthy fibre in your meal plan. "The science of weight loss is simple—eat fewer calories or work off more calories than what you eat," says Shetty.

There is, however, one diet that does things differently: the ketogenic or Keto diet. Created in the 1920s as a treatment for epilepsy, it eventually came to be used to provide metabolic protection against obesity and diabetes around the 1990s. The diet forces the body to burn fat instead of glucose for energy. Known as ketosis, the state is achieved when you consume three to four times more fat than carbs or protein. Having grown in popularity, such is the demand for the Keto diet that Lo! Foods, a low-carb and Keto-friendly range of packaged foods brand, was offered $500,000 by angel investors in 2019; in 2021, it raised another $1 million.

Priya Dogra, 46, a Keto coach and follower, says the diet helped her shed almost 40 kg—from 100 to 64—in a year. But it must be remembered that Keto is no magic wand for weight loss. A September 2018 study published in the *Indian Journal of Medical Research* found that the diet showed a dramatic improvement in weight loss in the short term, but in the long run, it can increase morbidity and mortality and is rarely sustainable. There were concerns about constipation and nutritional deficiencies, too. "I have had patients who come with elevated lipid profiles or fatty liver disease because of Keto. They eat more fat but don't reduce carbohydrates and their body is not in ketosis, so the fat is stored and not burned,"